HILCHOT HANUKKAH – SHULHAN ARUKH

Blessings, Which Way to Light & Hanukkah Meets Shabbat

Hilchot Hanukkah I Siman 676–681

Dayan Daniel Kada · Thursday Night Halacha · Shiur 6 of 7 Shulḥan Arukh, Oraḥ Ḥayim 676, 678, 679, 680 and 681 (677 held over for the final shiur)

Where We Are

Siman	Topic
670	What is forbidden on Hanukah: eulogies, fasts, work
671	Positioning the menorah; lighting in the synagogue
672	The correct time
673	Fuels
674	Lighting from one light to the next
675	**The lighting** is the mitzvah, not the placing

Tonight: **as much as possible of the remaining chapters**, with the rest on the following Monday, "just in time to come to Hanukah, knowing all of the halachot of Hanukah together."

Siman 676: The Order of the Berachot and the Lighting

Seif 1: The three berachot

On the first night: **להדליק נר (של) חנוכה, שעשה נסים לאבותינו, שהחיינו**. If Sheheḥeyanu was missed on the first night, say it on the second, third, **even the eighth night**.

Recap and a new point: "נר חנוכה" vs. "נר של חנוכה"

- **The original text** (Gemara, Rishonim, Rambam) is **להדליק נר של חנוכה**. That is what **Ashkenazim** and the **Spanish & Portuguese** say, and what the original Sephardim said.
- Most Sephardi siddurim today say **להדליק נר חנוכה**, because of **the Arizal**: the initials ל-נ-ח spell **נחל**, a stream, which draws down **a stream of shefa** (Divine abundance).

The Ḥida's question: if so, why does everyone, including the women lighting Shabbat candles, say **להדליק נר של שבת**?

The answer: Shabbat has many aspects: the candles, the food, the dress. So "the light **of** Shabbat" is one aspect among many. **Hanukah's whole essence is the light. נר** and **חנוכה** are synonymous, so **נר חנוכה** fits.

Middle Eastern Sephardim say **נר חנוכה**, but the original Sephardi custom was **נר של חנוכה**. "Those should follow the minhag, whatever it is."

"בזמן הזה" or "ובזמן הזה"?

- **Ashkenazim and almost all Sephardim: בימים ההם בזמן הזה**: miracles for our ancestors **in those days**, thousands of years ago, **at this season**, on 25 Kislev.
- **Spanish & Portuguese** and some older texts: **בימים ההם ובזמן הזה**, "in those days **and** at this time," which can mean that **we pray and hope for miracles now as well**.

Follow your custom. Absent one, the general practice is **בזמן הזה**.

Forgot Sheheḥeyanu all eight nights: can you say it on the eighth day?

On the eighth **morning** someone realises they never said Sheheḥeyanu. Too late?

What is Sheheḥeyanu on: the festival, or the mitzvah of lighting? - On the **festivals**, the Gemara is clear: Sheheḥeyanu is **on the day itself**. On Yom Kippur we say it in shul, not over a candle. On Yom Tov, if there was no Kiddush, you'd still say it. On Sukkot, if you forgot until Ḥol HaMoed, **you say it then and there, walking down the street**. - **Some poskim** applied this to Hanukah: the berachah is on the special time, merely attached to the lighting, so you could say it on the eighth day. - **We do not hold this.** A **ḥag** has **kedushah**: it is from the Torah, a **regel**, with **tosefet** (adding to its sanctity). **Hanukah is not a ḥag.** It is a holy time in our calendar, but **the Sheheḥeyanu is on the new mitzvah**, which comes only once a year.

The main halacha: no Sheheḥeyanu on the eighth day without lighting, though one who did say it "would have what to rely on."

"Ḥag Ḥanukah Same'aḥ"? An aside

"What really bothers me: people who wish each other 'Ḥag Ḥanukah Same'aḥ'... It's a complete misuse of the word ḥag. It's not a ḥag."

A ḥag is one of the three regalim: Pesaḥ, Shavuot, Sukkot. Even **Rosh HaShanah** is imprecise: it is not a ḥag, nor a time of simḥah. Say "a good Yom Tov," "Shabbat Shalom," or anything else. When the Rabbi calls Hanukah a "festival," he means it "in a very loose sense: a special time in our calendar."

Seif 2: Finish all the berachot, then light

On the following nights you say **two** berachot. **Say all the berachot before beginning to light.**

Why does this need saying? Because there is an opinion that you should **start lighting immediately after the first berachah**, "to light," and say **שעשה נסים** while lighting. Its logic: **שעשה נסים is not intrinsic to the act of lighting.** It relates to **seeing** the lights (we will see that someone who only sees a menorah says it).

- **The custom of Beit El** and the **mekubalim**, brought by the **Kaf HaḤayim** and the **Ḥida**, and followed by many Sephardim, was to start lighting straight after the first berachah.
- **The Rabbi:** "Unless you are a kabbalist... it seems better halachically to wait to complete the berachot." While saying **שעשה נסים** and **שהחיינו** your mind should be focused, not "mucking around with the wicks."
- **The main halacha for both Ashkenazim and Sephardim: finish the berachot, then light.**

Forgot the berachah until after lighting the first light?

Fourth night: you lit the first light and realise you never said **להדליק**. Normally, once a mitzvah is done, it's too late for its berachah.

A class member: the first light is the night's mitzvah, and it's done. The others are only hiddur. **The Rabbi:** but hiddur is still part of it. **You may still say the berachah**, because **as long as you are engaged in the mitzvah**, even its extra parts, you can bless.

Parallels: - **Arba minim:** you're told to hold the etrog upside down for the berachah, but people forget and pick everything up together. The mitzvah is technically done, yet **you still bless**, on the waving and the circuits, all part of one big mitzvah. - **Tefillin:** the mitzvah is tying the shel yad. You should bless first, but if you tied it and then blessed, it's fine; the remaining straps are still part of the mitzvah.

An aside on tefillin: the **Shulḥan Arukh rules** explicitly that you tie the shel yad, **immediately** put on the shel rosh without interruption, and **only then** wind the seven straps, which are not intrinsic to the mitzvah. "In practice, I don't know any community which does this. Even the Spanish and Portuguese." The **Arizal** said to wind the seven straps first, and that spread.

Seif 3: Birkat HaRo'eh, the berachah on seeing

Someone who has not lit and has no one lighting for them, and sees a Hanukah menorah, says **שעשה נסים** (and on the first night **שהחיינו**), but **not להדליק**, since they are not lighting.

Who qualifies?

	The Rambam	The Rashba, the Ran (the halacha)
The condition	Simply **not lighting yourself** that night	**Not lighting AND no one lighting for your home**
Example	A Sephardi yeshivah student whose parents light at home	A traveller in a hotel that forbids lighting, single, with no household lighting for them

On yeshivah students: a Sephardi student financially supported by his parents (they pay for the yeshivah, food and plane tickets) is **part of their household** and **does not light**. "When I was in yeshivah, I didn't light a menorah. I relied on my parents." **By the Rambam**, seeing Ashkenazi friends light, he would say the berachah of seeing. **The Rashba and Ran disagree**: if your home is lit for you, it is as if you have lit.

The Beit Yosef writes that the Rambam reads the Gemara more precisely, **but rules like the Rashba and Ran**. So the situation is rare: you would need to have **no way to light** and **no household lighting for you**.

Continuing the case: that traveller said **שעשה נסים and שהחיינו** on seeing a menorah on the first night. On the **second night**, back home, he lights his own and **does not repeat שהחיינו**. Earlier we concluded you cannot say Sheheḥeyanu on the day itself without lighting, **but in association with seeing the lights you can**, and he has.

The husband who comes home at 1 a.m. on the first night

The first night is a big work event; he gets home at midnight or 1 a.m. As discussed, if he'll be home after 8 or 9 pm, **his wife or children light** at the proper time and he fulfils the mitzvah through them. On the **second night** he comes home in time and lights **himself for the first time**. **Does he say Sheheḥeyanu?**

	Ruling
Mishnah Berurah (Seif Katan 16)	**No.** His wife did it on his behalf the night before
Ḥacham Ovadia	**Yes**, on the basis of a **triple doubt** (ספק ספקא)

Ḥacham Ovadia's reasoning: 1. Some poskim hold that since **he did not actively perform** the mitzvah, he says Sheheḥeyanu the next night. 2. A further opinion supports saying it. (The Rabbi was not entirely clear on this point.) 3. **A general principle worth knowing: ספק ברכות להקל does not really apply to Sheheḥeyanu.** It is a berachah of **personal thanksgiving and happiness**, so we are more lenient in saying it.

Ruling (Ḥacham Ovadia): say Sheheḥeyanu on the second night in this case.

Seif 4: הנרות הללו

After lighting, we say **הנרות הללו אנו מדליקין על התשועות ועל הנסים ועל הנפלאות...**

- **The Gemara does not mention it.** It comes from **Massechet Soferim** (8th–9th century), "not part of the Talmud... a much later addition," printed at the end of one of the tractates.
- **Two texts exist.** The **Arizal** required **exactly 36 words**, corresponding to the 36 lights of Hanukah (excluding shamashim), and changed the text accordingly. The **old Spanish & Portuguese** siddur and many old Sephardi siddurim (**Syria, Iraq**) have the earlier text.

The Syrian tune: "When I was younger and used to be particular about these things," the Rabbi would try to fit the Arizal's 36 words into the special **Syrian melody**, but it never worked. "Then I realised, actually, it's the wrong thing to do. **You follow the minhag, and just say what your father said**, even if it's not in line with the Arizal."

A participant noted that their siddur cites the **Maharam of Rothenburg** as the source of the alternative version. The Rabbi: that is the Ashkenazi version (with **הנרות הללו** itself, more than 36 words). The point is that before the Arizal there were various texts, and the Arizal specified 36.

Timing matters: say **הנרות הללו only after the first light has been lit.** "What I sometimes see, and you should be careful with: as soon as people finish the berachot they start saying הנרות הללו. That's wrong." The berachah must **take effect on at least one light** first. הנרות הללו is a lovely **post-Talmudic** text, not part of the berachot, and it would be an **interruption** between the berachah and lighting the first light.

Seif 5: Which direction?

Picture your menorah. On the first night you light the light on the **right**. Each night you add a light **to its left**.

	Sephardim (Shulḥan Arukh), all Sephardim	The Vilna Gaon (some Ashkenazim)
Start with	**The new light**, the leftmost of the night	**The same first light every night**, the one nearest the doorway
Direction	**Left to right**	**Right to left**
Reasoning	1) Every turn should be **toward the right**. 2) Bless on **the new light**: a new night, a new miracle	Why bless on a **hiddur** light rather than the main one? And the berachah should be on the light **nearest the doorway** (**סמוך לפתח**), the more important mitzvah. Moving right is a principle, but a greater principle is to bless on the main light

Kenneth confirmed that some Ashkenazim always begin with the same light each night.

Siman 678: When Money Is Short

נר ביתו (נר של שבת) קודם לנר חנוכה, משום שלום בית. *The Shabbat light takes precedence over the Hanukah light, because of peace in the home.*

If you cannot afford, or cannot find, fuel for both, buy **Shabbat** candles.

Why not one candle for both? (A participant suggested אין עושין מצוות חבילות חבילות, not bundling mitzvot together. True, "but much simpler.") **Their purposes are opposite.** The Shabbat light is **for benefit**: you enjoy it and eat by it, which was its whole purpose before electricity. The Hanukah light **may not be used**.

Obviously: if you can afford one Shabbat candle and one Hanukah light, or two Shabbat candles, light one of each. Two Shabbat candles are nice, but **one fulfils the mitzvah**.

The Mishnah Berurah's puzzle (work it out yourself)

You have one Shabbat candle and one Hanukah light, and money for **one more**. It's the second or third night. **A second Shabbat candle, or an extra Hanukah light?**

Mark: the extra **Hanukah** light. The Shabbat candle already provides shalom bayit, and the extra Hanukah light is hiddur.

Exactly. The hiddur of Hanukah is in the Gemara; **nowhere does it say to light two Shabbat candles**. That is a much later custom. **Paradoxically: one Shabbat candle comes before one Hanukah light, but after that, Hanukah lights come before a second Shabbat candle.**

- **"But Shabbat is more frequent (tadir)!"** Tadir decides only which to do **first** when you do both. Here you are doing both mitzvot.
- **A good point raised:** even if you can afford only a **second** light on the **eighth** night, there is still value in lighting extra lights, even short of the full number.

Shabbat candles or Kiddush wine? (from Hilchot Shabbat, two years earlier)

Maria suggested **Kiddush**, since it is d'oraita. **The Rabbi:** "Your logic is sound, but don't forget: **you can make Kiddush on bread**." So buy **Shabbat candles** and make Kiddush on the ḥallah.

Hanukah or Kiddush wine?

Having secured Shabbat candles, spend the rest on **Hanukah lights**, **יקנה לנר חנוכה משום פרסומי ניסא.** .not wine; make Kiddush on bread. **The Rema:** Hanukah lights also come before **Havdalah wine**

The full hierarchy: 1. **Shabbat candle** 2. **Hanukah light** 3. **Wine for Kiddush** 4. **Wine for Havdalah**

"Even though of all these, **Kiddush is the most important**, Kiddush has an **alternative**." **The Mishnah Berurah's caveat:** all this assumes you have bread. With no bread for Kiddush, spend the money on grape juice.

Siman 679: Friday Afternoon: Which Candles First?

On Friday, light the Hanukah lights first, then the **בערב שבת מדליקין נר חנוכה תחלה, ואחר כך נר שבת.** *.Shabbat candles*

"Everyone does this, but it's actually not simple at all."

Behind it: the Ba'al Halachot Gedolot (Behag, about 1,200 years ago), the source of the custom for women to light Shabbat candles **and then** say the berachah: - Shabbat begins at sunset, or **from pelag haminḥah** whenever a person **explicitly accepts it**; after that, melachah is forbidden (at least rabbinically, possibly biblically; even then only a negative prohibition, not the full Shabbat penalty). - **The Behag: lighting Shabbat candles is itself an acceptance of Shabbat.** So light **Hanukah first**, or you would have accepted Shabbat and could no longer light.

	Position
Ashkenazim	**Follow the Behag**: lighting Shabbat candles accepts Shabbat
Sephardim (Shulḥan Arukh)	**Do not.** Lighting Shabbat candles does not necessarily accept Shabbat, especially if one has in mind not to
The Rashba	Rejects the Behag, and says **Shabbat candles first**, because **they are more frequent** (tadir)

So why does the Shulḥan Arukh rule Hanukah first? The Ba'ḤH explains with a principle worth remembering:

When there is a dispute in halacha, even if you don't hold like that opinion, if it's easy to satisfy it and it makes no significant difference, do it. Why enter into a dispute?

The Rashba's tadir argument is counterbalanced (**many disagreed** with him, since there are considerations on both sides, such as pirsumei nisa), which leaves the Behag. We don't follow the Behag, but **what's wrong with lighting Hanukah first?**

If you lit Shabbat candles first by mistake (Shabbat has not yet begun):

	Ruling
Sephardim, men or women	**Light the Hanukah lights afterwards.** Absolutely fine
Ashkenazim, a man	May still light
Ashkenazim, a woman	**Should not** light (her husband, or someone else, can). If she is alone with no one to light for her, she does not light

Enough fuel, and Minḥah

- The berachah is said even in daylight, since it is **from pelag haminḥah**. The fuel must last until **half an hour after nightfall**, about **an hour and a half**, which is a problem with ordinary small candles. At least **one light** should last that long.
- **The Mishnah Berurah (Seif Katan 2):** "some Aḥaronim" say to pray **Minḥah early**, then light Hanukah and Shabbat candles, then go to shul for Kabbalat Shabbat. **The first to say this was the Pri Megadim, about 300 years ago.** In the Rishonim's time the prevalent custom was to light at home, come to shul, light there and pray Minḥah.
- **The Pri Megadim's concern:** praying the previous day's Minḥah after lighting for the following night looks like a contradiction. **Some went so far** as to say it is better to pray Minḥah **alone** than after lighting.
- **The Rabbi:** very hard to accept. **Minyan** is a far older concept, and this idea is "300 years old at most." It is a good thing to pray early when you can (that year, with **Boxing Day on the Thursday**, perhaps many would be off work on Friday), but in a normal year it is fine to light at home and then pray Minḥah. **It isn't really a contradiction:** "I'm lighting it now **in preparation** for the night which is coming in half an hour's time," only because I can't light on Shabbat.

Siman 680: Protect the Lights on Friday Night

צריך ליזהר... שיניח דבר מפסיק בין הנרות לפתח: put something between the lights and the door, so that opening and closing it won't **inevitably** blow them out.

- This applies on weekdays too (don't leave a menorah where it will certainly go out), but on **Shabbat** it is more severe, since extinguishing is a Shabbat prohibition.
- It concerns a **פסיק רישא**, where extinguishing is inevitable or very likely. **An unexpected gust** when you open the door carries **no responsibility** from either the Hanukah or the Shabbat perspective.
- **"Use your common sense."**

The old door-holder: some used to set the light **in a holder on the door itself**. On Shabbat that is impossible: each time the door moves, the oil moves toward or away from the flame, raising **muktzeh** and **extinguishing or kindling** issues. (There is an opinion based on **פסיק רישא דלא ניחא ליה**, but "it's not really relevant.")

Siman 681: Motza'ei Shabbat: Havdalah or Menorah First?

אין מבדילין בנר חנוכה, שאין נהנים לאורו. *One may not use the Hanukah light for Havdalah, since one may not benefit from it.*

Why? (from Hilchot Havdalah, learned about a year before) **בורא מאורי האש** is a **berachah of praise**, commemorating the benefit of fire given to **Adam HaRishon**. You may only say it **when you are benefiting from the light**. The Hanukah light may not be used, so it can't serve for Havdalah.

In the synagogue: menorah first

Light the menorah, then Havdalah. Normally we try not to do melachah until real Havdalah (even after **אתה חוננתנו**), and Havdalah is more frequent. **But because of pirsumei nisa**, and because after Havdalah everyone leaves, the custom is to **light first**. This is the **universal custom in synagogues**.

At home: both are acceptable

For Havdalah first	For the menorah first
Tadir: Havdalah is more frequent	**Pirsumei nisa**: "a beautiful mitzvah, a special mitzvah"
Better not to do melachah before Havdalah	
At home it isn't public	

"There's no correct answer here." **דעביד כמר עביד, ודעביד כמר עביד**: whichever you follow is fine. **The general Sephardi practice**, in the Rabbi's experience: **Havdalah first at home, then the menorah**.

Summary

1. **676:1:** three berachot. The original text is **נר של חנוכה**. The Arizal's **נר חנוכה** spells **נחל**, and differs from **נר של שבת** because Hanukah's whole essence is the light. **בזמן הזה** (most) vs. **ובזמן הזה** (S&P).
2. **No Sheheḥeyanu on the eighth day** without lighting: it is on the **mitzvah**, and Hanukah is **not a ḥag**. (Please don't say "Ḥag Ḥanukah Same'aḥ.")
3. **676:2: finish the berachot, then light** (not the kabbalistic custom). Forgot the berachah until after the first light? **You can still say it** while engaged in the mitzvah (compare arba minim and tefillin).
4. **676:3:** the **berachah on seeing** applies only to someone with **no way to light and no household lighting for them** (Rashba, Ran, Beit Yosef). A husband whose family lit for him on the first night **says Sheheḥeyanu** on the second (Ḥacham Ovadia's triple doubt; Sheheḥeyanu is personal joy).
5. **676:4: הנרות הללו** is from **Massechet Soferim**. Say it **only after the first light is lit**. Follow your family's text, 36 words (Arizal) or not.
6. **676:5: Sephardim** begin with **the new light** and go **left to right**. **The Gra:** always begin with the light nearest the door.
7. **678: Shabbat candle → Hanukah light → Kiddush wine → Havdalah wine.** After one Shabbat candle and one Hanukah light, **extra Hanukah lights beat a second Shabbat candle**.
8. **679: Hanukah lights before Shabbat candles**, to avoid the Behag's dispute "when it's easy." Lit Shabbat candles first? **Sephardim:** still light Hanukah. Ashkenazi women: not. Pray Minḥah early if possible, but lighting before Minḥah is fine.
9. **680:** keep the lights from being **inevitably** blown out by the door on Shabbat.
10. **681: no Havdalah on the Hanukah light**. **In shul: menorah, then Havdalah. At home:** either, and Sephardim usually **Havdalah first**.

Coming Up

The final shiur, on Monday evening, 6:30–7:30 (not the usual 6:00): **682** (Al HaNissim), **683** (Hallel) and **684** (the Torah reading), each short, followed by **677**, the big chapter on **guests and travellers over Hanukah**.

A vote: for the new year (starting in January), **Hilchot Purim**, which can be completed in two months, or **Hilchot Pesaḥ**, which is huge and could not be finished in three months, "but it's Pesaḥ."

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